

US backtracks on mediation claims in Kashmir: Send the message

US President Donald Trump is not known to be **circumspect**. In 2019, during his first term, he **claimed** that Prime Minister Narendra Modi had asked him to **mediate** between India and Pakistan on Kashmir. Then, Washington backtracked and said the US would **step in** only if asked to do so by both countries. A similar script **played out** after the agreement between India and Pakistan to stop military action last week. First, Trump announced the **ceasefire** on his social media handles even before Indian and Pakistani authorities could do so. Second, he had used “trade”, he suggested, as a way to pressure Delhi and Islamabad. Third, the claim that the US “mediated” an end to the conflict. On Wednesday morning, the US State Department all but **walked back** on the theory that Washington was looking to play a part in the Kashmir issue. “We also welcome the ceasefire between India and Pakistan... We urge both sides to maintain direct communication to **preserve** regional stability,” its spokesperson said.

Earlier, Delhi had already **put paid to** any suggestion that the Kashmir issue was being internationalised. It provided a detailed timeline that showed it was Pakistan that first **approached** it to end the cycle of **escalation**. India **reiterated** that it would not **give in** to “nuclear blackmail” and the only issues to be discussed **bilaterally** were cross-border terror and the illegal **occupation** in PoK. That said, it is also important to understand that “**internationalising**” the Kashmir issue **is** easier said than done. For the better part of 75 years — especially in the last three **decades**, as India **outpaced** Pakistan **economically** and **de-hyphenated** itself diplomatically — Delhi has **thwarted** Islamabad’s attempts to make Kashmir a global talking point. Today, India’s national power is far greater, as it carefully **navigates** the Trump era.

Less than five months into his second term, Trump has thrown the global order into **flux**. He has reversed the US position on the Ukraine conflict, **imposed** and reduced tariffs, **lifted sanctions** on Syria and even claimed that the US and Iran are close to a nuclear deal. India has done better than most in negotiating the challenges **thrown up** by this **uncertainty**, ensuring that its relationship with the US continues to **deepen** and **widen**. As the **hostilities** with Pakistan **ebb**, Delhi must continue to wait and watch. It need not overreact to Trump’s claims but it must keep **underlining** its message to him.

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where ‘red’ denotes ‘subject’ and ‘blue’ denotes ‘verb’.

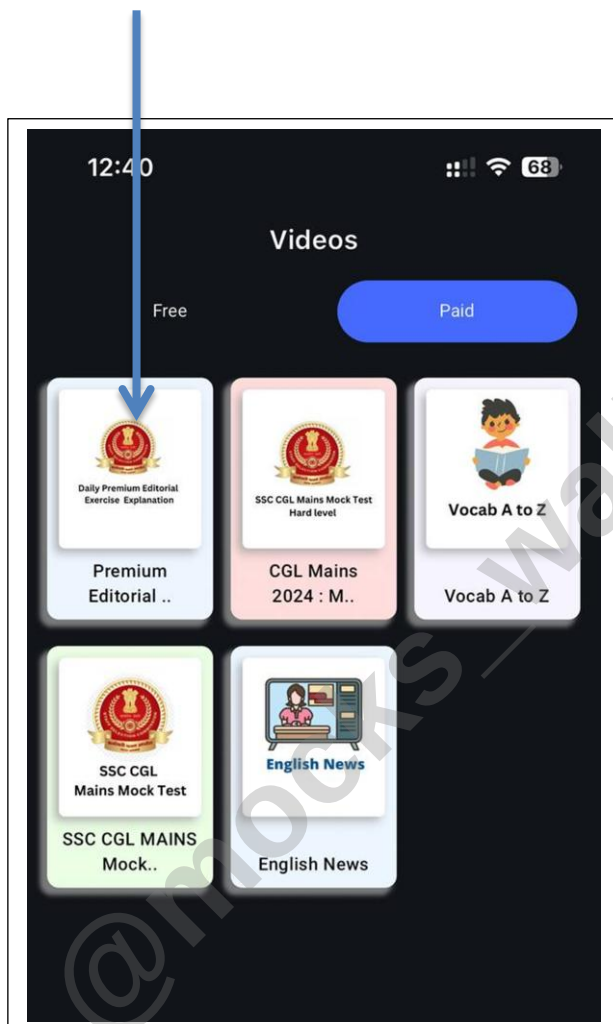
[Practice Exercise]

Vocabulary

1. **Backtrack** (verb) – retract, withdraw, reverse, retreat, rescind पीछे हटना / मुकर जाना
2. **Mediation** (noun) – negotiation, arbitration, conciliation, intervention, intercession मध्यस्थता
3. **Circumspect** (adjective) – cautious, prudent, wary, careful, vigilant सावधान / सतर्क
4. **Claim** (verb) – assert, state, allege, maintain, declare दावा करना
5. **Mediate** (verb) – arbitrate, negotiate, intervene, reconcile, conciliate मध्यस्थता करना
6. **Step in** (phrasal verb) – intervene, intercede, get involved, enter, interfere हस्तक्षेप करना
7. **Play out** (phrasal verb) – unfold, happen, occur, transpire, take place घटित होना
8. **Ceasefire** (noun) – truce, armistice, suspension of hostilities, peace agreement, stand-down युद्धविराम
9. **Walk back** (phrasal verb) – retract, reverse, withdraw, reconsider, correct पीछे हटना (बयान या दावा)
10. **Preserve** (verb) – maintain, safeguard, protect, uphold, conserve बनाए रखना
11. **Put paid to** (phrase) – end, destroy, ruin, cancel, terminate समाप्त कर देना
12. **Approach** (verb) – contact, reach out, move toward, request, propose संपर्क करना / पास आना
13. **Escalation** (noun) – intensification, increase, rise, amplification, aggravation बढ़ाव / उग्रता
14. **Reiterate** (verb) – repeat, restate, affirm, emphasize, echo दोहराना
15. **Give in** (phrasal verb) – surrender, yield, concede, succumb, submit झुक जाना / हार मान लेना
16. **Bilaterally** (adverb) – mutually, two-sidedly, reciprocally, between both parties, jointly द्विपक्षीय रूप से
17. **Occupation** (noun) – control, seizure, invasion, capture, colonization कब्जा
18. **Decade** (noun) – Period of ten year दशक
19. **Outpace** (verb) – surpass, exceed, outstrip, outperform, eclipse आगे निकल जाना
20. **Economically** (adverb) – financially, fiscally, monetarily, commercially, budgetarily आर्थिक रूप से

21. **De-hyphenate** (verb) – separate, disconnect, unlink, decouple, individualize अलग करना (राजनयिक संदर्भ में)
22. **Thwart** (verb) – prevent, foil, hinder, obstruct, frustrate विफल करना / रोकना
23. **Navigate** (verb) – manage, steer, handle, maneuver, direct मार्गदर्शन करना / संचालन करना
24. **Era** (noun) – period, age, epoch, time, generation युग / काल
25. **Flux** (noun) – instability, change, uncertainty, fluctuation, turbulence अनिश्चितता / परिवर्तनशीलता
26. **Impose** (verb) – enforce, implement, inflict, levy, apply थोपना / लागू करना
27. **Throw up** (phrasal verb) – produce, create, cause, generate, bring forth उत्पन्न करना
28. **Uncertainty** (noun) – unpredictability, doubt, instability, ambiguity, confusion अनिश्चितता
29. **Deepen** (verb) – strengthen, intensify, enhance, broaden, increase गहरा करना
30. **Widen** (verb) – expand, broaden, enlarge, extend, amplify चौड़ा करना / फैलाना
31. **Hostility** (noun) – animosity, enmity, conflict, aggression, opposition शत्रुता
32. **Ebb** (verb) – decline, decrease, wane, fall, downturn घटना
33. **Underline** (verb) – emphasize, highlight, stress, underscore, reinforce जोर देना

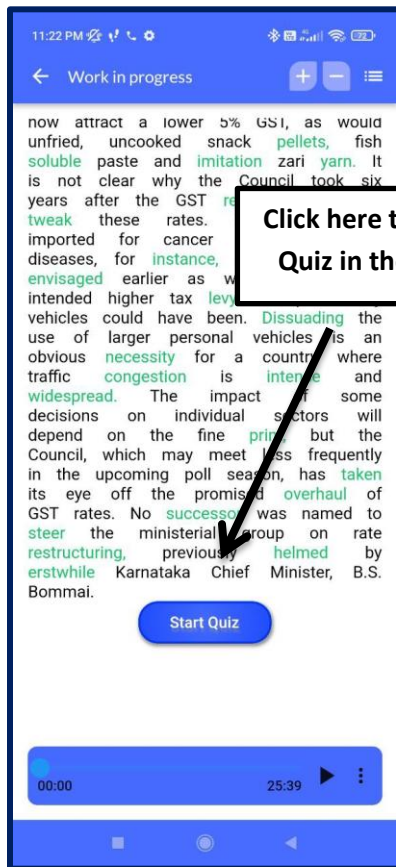
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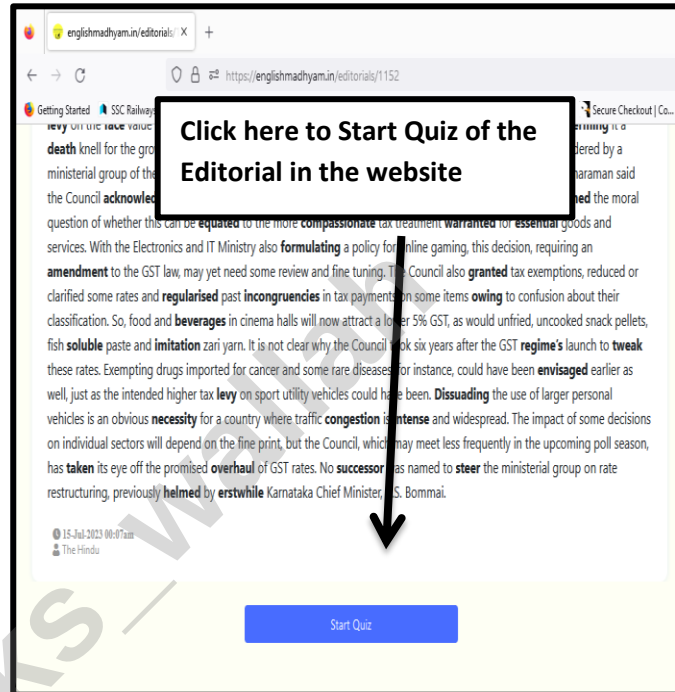
Summary of the Editorial

1. President Donald Trump claimed in 2019 that PM Modi had asked him to mediate between India and Pakistan on Kashmir.
2. The U.S. later backtracked, clarifying mediation would only occur if both countries requested it.
3. A similar situation unfolded recently after a ceasefire agreement between India and Pakistan.
4. Trump prematurely announced the ceasefire on social media, ahead of official statements from either country.
5. He also implied that “trade” was used to pressure Delhi and Islamabad into agreement.
6. Trump claimed U.S. mediation ended the conflict, a position later softened by official channels.
7. The U.S. State Department clarified it welcomed the ceasefire but urged direct bilateral communication between India and Pakistan.
8. India firmly rejected any third-party role, providing a timeline that showed Pakistan initiated the de-escalation.
9. Delhi reiterated its focus on cross-border terror and illegal occupation of PoK as the only bilateral concerns.
10. India dismissed “nuclear blackmail” and resisted any effort to internationalise the Kashmir issue.
11. Over decades, India has successfully thwarted Pakistan’s global campaign to highlight Kashmir.
12. India's growing economic and diplomatic strength has made it harder for Islamabad to gain global traction on the issue.
13. Amid global unpredictability in Trump’s second term, India has navigated U.S. shifts effectively.
14. Despite Trump’s erratic global policies, India-U.S. ties have continued to strengthen.
15. India should avoid overreacting to Trump’s statements but consistently reaffirm its stance on bilateralism and sovereignty.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



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